uncost.org

Living should not have a price tag.
Uncost the cost of living.

The Case for Uncost

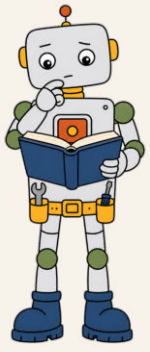
Why the cost of staying alive keeps climbing while AI and robotics could bring it down — and what we intend to do about it.



First edition · August 2026

Contents

Why this movement exists	03
The scale of it	05
What Uncost is	06
What Uncost is not	07
How a cost gets uncosted	08
The four parts	09
The fifteen Sectors	10
Where this stands today	11
How to take part	12
References	13



Why this movement exists

For most people, life keeps getting more expensive.

Every year, humanity produces more. More food than any generation before us. More housing. More energy. More of nearly everything, made with less human effort than at any point in recorded history. Artificial intelligence now performs work that recently required whole departments. Robotics has transformed farms, factories, warehouses and logistics. By every measure of capacity, we are richer than we have ever been.

And yet, for most people, life keeps getting more expensive.

Rent rises faster than pay. Groceries cost more than they did last year, and the year before that. A hospital visit, a term of childcare, a month of electricity — each takes a larger share of a household's income than it used to. Millions of people are working more hours than their parents did, with less security, to afford the same things their parents took for granted.

This is the contradiction at the centre of modern life, and it is not a feeling. It is measurable, it is documented by the institutions whose job is to measure it — and Uncost exists to lay it out plainly, with every source shown.

Where the gains are going

Automation has been extraordinarily effective at reducing the cost of production. That is not in dispute. The question is who receives the benefit when it does.

When a company automates, its costs fall and its value rises. That value accrues to whoever owns the company. And ownership in most economies is concentrated to a degree that is easy to state and hard to absorb.

The United States Federal Reserve publishes this quarterly. In its most recent figures, the bottom half of American households — over sixty million households — collectively hold about one per cent of the corporate equities and mutual fund shares owned outside retirement accounts. The wealthiest one per cent hold about half. And measured across everything — homes, savings, pensions, businesses — the top one per cent still hold roughly thirty per cent of total household net worth.

Read those numbers together and the mechanism becomes plain. When automation makes a company more valuable, essentially none of that gain reaches half the country. It reaches the people who already hold the assets.

The technology that could make living cheaper is instead making ownership more valuable.

This is not an argument that anyone is doing something wrong. It is an argument that a system optimising for one outcome will not accidentally produce a different one. Automation lowers production costs; nothing in that process obliges anyone to pass the saving on to a family paying rent. If the benefit of the greatest productivity gain in human history is to reach ordinary households, someone has to do the deliberate work of making it happen.

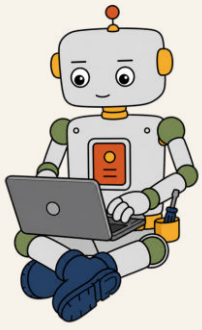
Nobody is currently doing that work systematically. That is why Uncost exists.

What we are proposing

Uncost is a nonprofit, nonpartisan movement with a narrow and testable aim: to reduce the real cost of the essentials, using evidence, artificial intelligence, robotics and open tools, and to publish every step so that anyone can check it or copy it.

The method is not complicated. Measure what essentials actually cost in a given place. Publish every source. Break each cost into its real components. Identify which components a specific technology could plausibly reduce. Package the result openly so that a community group, a co-operative, a nonprofit or a public body can act on it. Then go back and check honestly whether the cost actually fell.

We do not intend to own the resulting infrastructure. We make the case, do the math, publish the receipts — and stay alongside the communities that put the work to use, with playbooks, guidance and shared learning as they build.



The scale of it

If we cannot show you where a number came from, we do not print it.

Every figure in this section comes from the institution that publishes it. Each carries a reference number; the sources, with their links, are listed at the end of this paper — and each is recorded in a public register with its licence and the date it was last checked. If we cannot show you where a number came from, we do not print it.

745,652

people were homeless in the United States on a single night in January 2025 — 3 per cent fewer than a year earlier, but 26 per cent more than in 2013. Nearly 156,000 of them had been homeless long-term, the highest number ever counted. [1]

US Department of Housing and Urban Development, 2025 Annual Homelessness Assessment Report

12.1 million

American renter households spent more than half of everything they earned in 2024 simply to have somewhere to live. Across all renters, 22.7 million households — 49 per cent, a record — spent more than 30 per cent of their income on rent and utilities. [2]

Harvard Joint Center for Housing Studies, The State of the Nation's Housing 2026

1%

is the share of stocks and funds — those held outside retirement accounts — owned by the entire bottom half of American households. The wealthiest 1 per cent own about half. [3]

US Federal Reserve, Distributional Financial Accounts, Q1 2026

$26,993

was the average annual premium for an employer family health plan in 2025, up six per cent in a single year. Workers paid $6,850 of it themselves, before a single appointment. [4]

Kaiser Family Foundation, Employer Health Benefits Survey 2025

$80,080

a year is the cost of in-home care at the 2025 national median rate, for someone needing forty-four hours of help a week. Most families needing that care do not have it. [5]

CareScout, Cost of Care Survey 2025

$11,950

was the average published in-state tuition at a public four-year college for 2025-26 — $340 more than the year before, before housing, food or books. [6]

College Board, Trends in College Pricing 2025

$6.83

a pound is what ground beef cost in June 2026, up from $3.80 in January 2019 — about 80 per cent more. [7]

US Bureau of Labor Statistics, CPI Average Price Data, June 2026

18.83¢

per kilowatt-hour was the average US residential electricity price in April 2026, up from 17.55 cents a year earlier. [8]

US Energy Information Administration, Electric Power Monthly

A note on what these figures are and are not. They are overwhelmingly American, because American statistical agencies publish more open primary data than most. The pressure they describe is not confined to the United States, and extending this evidence base to other regions is among the first things this movement intends to do. We would rather show you a partial picture with sources attached than a global one we cannot stand behind.

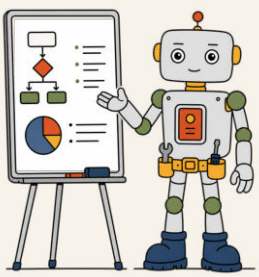
What Uncost is

Our part is to make it measurable, provable and copyable.

The mission. Uncost is a nonprofit, nonpartisan movement dedicated to lowering the real cost of living for everyone — using projects, data, artificial intelligence, robotics and open-source tools. We measure what the essentials of life actually cost, work out where technology and shared infrastructure could genuinely bring those costs down, and publish everything openly so that communities anywhere can act on it.

The vision. A world where the gains of automation show up where people live — in the price of housing, food, power and care — not only in the value of assets. Where the basics of a good life keep getting cheaper instead of more expensive, and a person's survival no longer depends on winning a monthly race against their own bills. We will not build that world alone, and we do not claim to. Our part is to make it measurable, provable and copyable.

How we hold ourselves to it. Four working rules, each of which rules something out. Every public number carries its source, its date and its region — or it is not published. Negative results are published as prominently as wins; an organisation that reports only its successes is not doing research. Everything we produce is open for anyone to use without permission or fees. And a human being stays accountable for every claim, every decision and every dollar — AI is our subject and our tool, never our excuse.



What Uncost is not

Each of these may have been assumed, so each is worth stating.

Not a cryptocurrency, token or DAO. There is no coin, no wallet, nothing on-chain, and no plan for any. This is a deliberate exclusion, not an oversight.

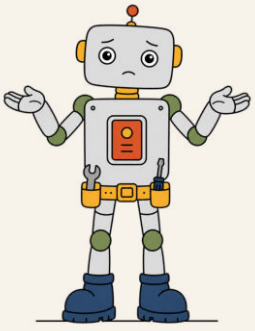
Not an argument against money, markets or business. Money is how the world coordinates, and markets are not the enemy — the price of staying alive is. The claim is narrower and testable: the real cost of specific essential things can be driven down by pointing existing technology at them, and sharing what works, free, with the communities that need it.

Not anti-work. We are against work being compulsory for survival, which is a different proposition. People should work for ambition, craft, contribution, curiosity and purpose. Whether you can eat should not depend on it.

Not aligned with any political party. Cost-of-living arguments drift toward partisanship easily. Describing a cost problem without assigning blame for it takes discipline, and we accept that discipline as the price of being useful to everyone.

Not a service provider. We do not build housing, deliver care, generate electricity, or hold anyone's data on their behalf. We produce evidence and open tools, and support the people who build with them.

Not yet an incorporated organisation, and not able to accept donations. What exists today — and what does not — is set out plainly near the end of this paper.



How a cost gets uncosted

Six steps, applied the same way every time.

Six steps, applied the same way every time, in every Sector.

1. **Measure.** Establish what a household in a defined region actually spends on the thing in question, using public data, with the date and the region attached.

2. **Publish.** Put the sources and assumptions up before the conclusions, so anyone can check the starting point rather than being asked to accept it.

3. **Break down.** Separate the price into its real components — land, energy, labour, materials, finance, regulation, maintenance. A cost you cannot decompose is a cost you cannot reduce.

4. **Match.** Identify which components a specific, named mechanism could plausibly move — and count what that mechanism adds as well as what it saves.

5. **Package.** Publish the model, the sources, the brief and the playbook so a community group, co-operative, nonprofit or public body can run it.

6. **Track.** Follow whether total cost actually falls where the approach is applied, and publish the answer either way.

The sixth step is what makes the other five worth doing. It is easy to propose that some technology would reduce a cost. It is much rarer to go back afterwards and check honestly whether it did.

The four pillars

The Movement

The public side: the pledge, the people, the argument made out loud. Its job is to demonstrate that enough people want this for institutions to pay attention. Nothing else in this paper happens without it.

The Case

The evidence: what living actually costs, region by region, every figure sourced. Its flagship is the Human Essentials Dashboard — a regional, source-led picture of what one person genuinely needs and what those needs cost where they live, showing which costs are rising, which are falling, and where automation could realistically intervene.

The Projects

The open tools: models, briefs, kits and playbooks that a community can copy, adapt and run. We build the planning models and the software; communities build the thing itself — and we stay available while they do.

The Assembly

The accountability structure: how supporters get a say in what gets researched next or changes to our policies, transparently and on the record. One person, one vote — contributions never buy influence, because a movement opposed to wealth determining outcomes cannot let wealth determine its own. At launch it is advisory; any binding authority would need legal structures that do not yet exist, and pretending otherwise would be dishonest.

Alongside The Assembly sits The Treasury: a public record of money received and money spent, so that anyone can see where support goes.



The fifteen Sectors

The cost-of-living problem is not one industry. We map what a person needs across fifteen Sectors, in a fixed order that does not change according to what is convenient.

01 
Food.
Nutrition, growing, processing, distribution and waste.

02 
Water.
Drinking water, sanitation, filtration and supply.

03 
Shelter.
Housing, land use, construction, maintenance and heating.

04 
Energy.
Electricity, heat, storage, microgrids and grid access.

05 
Healthcare.
Diagnostics, primary and basic care, medicines and devices.

06 
Care.
Childcare, eldercare, disability support and family care.

07 
Education.
Schooling, tutoring, skills and lifelong learning.

08 
Transportation.
Getting to work, public transit, vehicles, logistics and mobility.

09 
Clothing.
Apparel, footwear, textiles, repair and reuse.

10 
Goods.
Tools, appliances, furniture and shared access to them.

11 
Materials.
Raw inputs, recycling, reuse and local manufacturing.

12 
Communication.
Internet access, connectivity, devices and digital participation.

13 
Safety.
Emergency response, prevention, protection and access to justice.

14 
Environment.
Air, water and soil quality, and resilience to climate impacts.

15 
Leisure.
Culture, sport, shared public space and rest.

The first year concentrates on Shelter, Food and Energy, with Water next. That is a judgement about where cost pressure is heaviest and where evidence is most likely to lead somewhere useful — not a claim that the others matter less. Four Sectors are deliberately restricted: Healthcare, Care, education for children and Safety are treated as measurement-only. We will establish what those things cost and where the cost sits, but we will not package a tool for a community group to run — because putting technology between a person and their medical care, their child's education or their physical safety requires safeguarding review, professional oversight, insurance and accountable partners that do not yet exist. Where the method stops early, we say so and say why.

Where this stands today

We would rather show you an empty shelf than a full one we cannot stand behind.

This is the section most organisations would leave out. It is here because everything above depends on being trusted about numbers, and an organisation that is vague about its own position has no business asking anyone to trust its arithmetic.

What exists

A published method and a movement plan. Fifteen Sector dossiers. Ten draft policies and seven project briefs, all public and open to criticism. A public repository where the work can be inspected and corrected by anyone. A source register with its first verified entries, each traced to a primary document with its licence and refresh date.

What does not exist

Uncost is not incorporated. It has no confirmed fiscal sponsor. It cannot accept donations and has no tax-deductible status. No policy on the site has been adopted — every one is a draft awaiting review. The Assembly is not operating. The Human Essentials Dashboard is designed, not built. There are no employees, no offices and no revenue (yet).

The source register contains a small number of entries. That is not modesty; it is genuinely the beginning. We would rather show you an empty shelf than a full one we cannot stand behind.

Why say all this

Because the alternative is worse. An organisation that presents itself as further along than it is has to manage that gap forever, and the day someone notices is the day nothing it says is believed. Stating the position plainly costs some early enthusiasm and buys something considerably more durable.

How to take part

Sign the pledge. Free, and it takes a moment. Its only function is to show how many people want this — which is the argument that opens doors institutions would otherwise keep shut. It is the single most useful thing most people can do today.

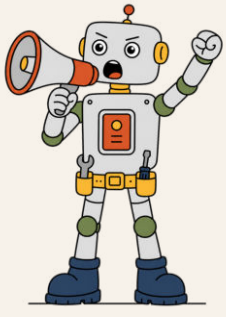
Contribute your skills. The most valuable work available right now is data collection and analysis: verifying figures against primary documents, reviewing source licences, checking methodology, researching individual Sectors, translating. This is the work that makes every public number defensible, and there is a great deal of it.

Partner. Researchers, technologists, co-operatives, community organisations and public-interest institutions can help build, test or apply the work. If you run something that could pilot a finding, that is the most useful conversation available to us.

> **Financial contribution is not yet possible.** Uncost is seeking fiscal sponsorship, and until that is confirmed it cannot accept donations or offer tax-deductible giving. When that changes it will be said plainly, not quietly.

The question is no longer whether humanity can produce enough. The question is why living is not getting cheaper — and who is going to do something about it.

Living should not have a price tag. If you think that is worth testing, join us to help Uncost the cost of living.



References

Each number below matches the bracketed reference beside its figure. Every source is a primary publication — the institution that measured it, not a summary of one — and each is recorded in the public source register at uncost.org with its licence and refresh cadence.

[1] US Department of Housing and Urban Development. The 2025 Annual Homelessness Assessment Report (AHAR) to Congress, Part 1: Point-in-Time Estimates. Published May 2026. huduser.gov/portal/sites/default/files/pdf/2025-AHAR-Part-1.pdf

[2] Harvard Joint Center for Housing Studies. The State of the Nation's Housing 2026. Published 17 June 2026. jchs.harvard.edu

[3] Board of Governors of the Federal Reserve System. Distributional Financial Accounts, 2026:Q1 (release of 18 June 2026). Corporate equities and mutual fund shares held outside retirement accounts, by wealth percentile. federalreserve.gov/releases/z1/dataviz/dfa/

[4] Kaiser Family Foundation. Employer Health Benefits 2025 Annual Survey. Published October 2025. kff.org

[5] CareScout (Genworth). Cost of Care Survey 2025. Published 2 March 2026. carescout.com

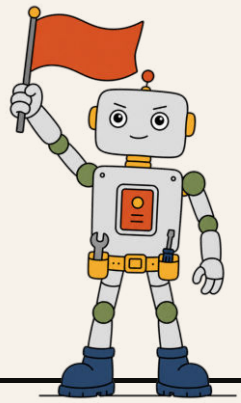
[6] College Board. Trends in College Pricing 2025. Published November 2025. research.collegeboard.org

[7] US Bureau of Labor Statistics. CPI Average Price Data: Ground beef, 100% beef, per lb. (453.6 gm) in U.S. city average, series APU0000703112. June 2026 data, released 14 July 2026. data.bls.gov/timeseries/APU0000703112

[8] US Energy Information Administration. Electric Power Monthly, Table 5.6.A. eia.gov/electricity/monthly/

Figures published by Harvard JCHS, the Kaiser Family Foundation, CareScout and the College Board are cited with attribution and remain the copyright of those institutions. Figures from US federal agencies are public-domain works. **The Federal Reserve top-1 per cent share is computed from the two published top wealth bins of the same release; the method is recorded in the source register. The ground beef change is computed between two published levels of the same BLS series; both levels are shown and the method is recorded in the source register.**

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Uncost.org — a nonprofit, nonpartisan movement.

contact@uncost.org

This paper may be shared freely. It describes a pre-launch project; every statement about the project's own status was accurate on the date shown and is intended to be corrected as circumstances change rather than defended.